The light of the old lamp fell across the table where Mr. Angier sat waiting.

He had come to St. Mary's Street late that evening, and the light in the window was the only light left on the road.

J. R. Smith met him at the door. “You can't stay here,” he said. “The house is not safe tonight.”

“I can wait,” said Angier. “Why should I leave?”

Smith lit a candle and set it beside the light. The candle burned low, and a thin light danced on the wall.

It was a contemporary house, built in the year of the great fire, with fresh paint and cold rooms. Mrs. Hale, the owner, had left for Dr. Brown's clinic.

Smith gave up the argument at last. He always gives up when the light fails, and tonight the light was failing fast.

Angier gave up his seat by the fire, because the heat was too much to bear.

“Who gives up first?” asked Smith. “I can tell you: the man with the weaker light.”

They talked of apples, pears, plums, etc. and of the light that comes in autumn. A good light makes a quiet house feel warm.

The light moved. Light fell on the floor, light fell on the stairs, and the whole light of the evening seemed to gather in the hall.

Angier smiled. He did not give up easily, and the light told him so.

By midnight the candle was gone. Only the grey light of the moon remained, and that light was enough.

“Stay,” Smith said at last. “The light will be better in the morning.”

So they sat, two men and one light, until the first light of dawn.

Light, light, light: the light was everywhere. The light was kind, the light was thin, the light was gold, and every light was a small light.

He watched the light. She watched the light. They all watched the light grow, and the light grew, and the light held.

In the end the light won. Mr. Angier rose, thanked Smith, and walked out into the light of a new day. A last light burned behind him.

Some say a light like that never fades. Others say each light must fade. Either way the light was real, and the light was theirs.

Later the light came back to the house on St. Mary's Street, and the light stayed. The light is there still, the old light.